

# Chicago Tribune



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Artist Pablo Serrano stands by a new painting on March 10 in his Pilsen studio. **BRIAN CASSELLA/CHICAGO TRIBUNE**

## WHO GETS TO BE AN AMERICAN?

Locals with birthright citizenship hope the practice prevails as Supreme Court set to weigh in on issue

By Angie Leventis Lourgos | CHICAGO TRIBUNE

As the son of an undocumented mother and father, Pablo Serrano of Chicago says it would be painful for him — and harmful to the nation — if America were to end its longstanding practice of birthright citizenship for future generations.

His mom was seven months pregnant when his parents left Durango, Mexico, in summer 1979, searching for a better life and reuniting with other family members in the United States.

She gave birth to Serrano at the old Cook County Hospital just a few months after their arrival. The newborn became an automatic U.S. citizen by virtue of his place of birth, according to the 14th Amendment and well-established American law, despite his mixed-status family.

Yet on the first day of Donald Trump's second term, the president signed an executive order on birthright citizenship declaring that some children whose parents are here illegally or temporarily, such as certain visa holders, are not American citizens.

The order, which has been blocked by the courts, would apply to children born on or after Feb. 19, 2025, potentially affecting the status of millions of babies.

It has also ignited broader political and public debate over who should have the right to call themselves an American, based on the circumstances of their birth and parentage.

As an American with birthright citizenship, Serrano worries that if Trump's order were allowed to go into effect "we will be deporting babies soon," with a spiral of consequences that could reshape the legal and cultural landscape of the country.

"Whether you're from Ireland, Italy, Mexico, Colombia, Venezuela, China, if you were blessed to be born here, you are a citizen of this country," said Serrano, an artist in the Pilsen neighborhood and father of three. "I don't think people fully understand what that means" for the spirit and fabric of the nation.

The Supreme Court will soon decide the constitutionality of Trump's attempt to restrict birthright citizenship, which conflicts with more than

See **CITIZEN** on Page A10

## Assaults on riders, workers beset CTA

Passengers attacked at least twice as often as on other transit agencies

By Talia Soglin and Joe Mahr  
CHICAGO TRIBUNE

Workers and passengers on the Chicago Transit Authority have been assaulted at rates at least double those of comparable public transit systems around the country, according to a Tribune analysis of federal data.

The analysis comes as the Trump administration has accused the CTA of doing too little to address violent crime on mass transit, in another front of the political war between the feds and leaders in deep blue Illinois.

In 2024, the most recent year with complete data, the CTA reported passenger assaults at a rate up to five times as high as those of comparable mass transit systems, when adjusting each system for the volume of ridership. Passengers were more likely to be assaulted on the CTA than the mass transit systems in New York, Los Angeles, Boston, Philadelphia and Washington, D.C., according to the analysis.

Chicago saw a jump in the passenger assault rate during the pandemic, like other major systems. But as ridership bounced back, most other comparable systems generally saw a drop in assault rates. Chicago didn't — instead seeing its rate steadily rise through 2024. Reports of passenger assaults began dropping in 2025, although not enough data has been released for last year to compute complete, comparable rates among the systems.

See **CTA** on Page A6

### INSIDE



BRYNN ANDERSON/AP

### On to the Sweet 16

The No. 3 seed Illini were on their offensive game Saturday night, putting on a show in the second round of the NCAA Tournament. Illinois beat 11th-seeded VCU 76-55 to advance to the Sweet 16, and will play No. 2 seed Houston on Thursday. **Sports**

### Dreams for future

What should Chicago be like in 2050? Tribune Opinion is joining with World Business Chicago to commission 16 distinguished Chicago writers to imagine and envision the city's future. Former Tribune columnist Mary Schmich goes first. **Opinion, Page B2**

### Iran attacks base

Tehran targeted a joint U.S.-U.K. base on Diego Garcia in the Indian Ocean, and Iran's main nuclear enrichment site was struck again. **Nation & World, Page B6**

## A push to protect marine wonder on South Side

Advocates fear plan to protect lakefront may harm Morgan Shoal

By Christiana Freitag  
CHICAGO TRIBUNE

A few hundred feet off the shoreline of Kenwood and Hyde Park lives an underwater marvel few Chicagoans ever see: the remnants of a 400 million-year-old coral reef scattered with ancient fossils and the wreckage of the Silver Spray, a steamship that sank after striking the shallow bedrock in 1914.

For free diver Jessica Christopher, the milelong stretch of underwater dolomite known as

Morgan Shoal is a rare natural refuge along Chicago's otherwise engineered lakefront.

When the weather warms, Christopher can glide over fossilized coral and sponge formations while fish weave through the crevices of the shallow bedrock.

A Logan Square resident and former competitive swimmer, Christopher first visited Hyde Park in 2012 to experience the shoal's unusually crystal clear, sand-free waters. She returns to Morgan Shoal for the community of swimmers that gathers above it — often meeting atop the sunken ship's boiler, which emerges during periods of low water levels.

See **SHOAL** on Page A8



Waves crash into older limestone blocks and wooden pylons along the lakefront by 49th Street on March 12 near Morgan Shoal. **BRIAN CASSELLA/CHICAGO TRIBUNE**

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### WEATHER FORECAST

**TODAY** H: 46 L: 29  
**MON.** H: 43 L: 30  
**TUE.** H: 55 L: 41  
Complete details on Page B12

### INDEX

Almanac ..... A15  
Crossword ... In Comics  
Editorials ..... B1

Horoscope ... In Comics  
Letters ..... B4  
Obituaries ..... A16

Rides ..... G7  
Success ..... G4  
Television ..... D7

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